President's Annual Report 2013 – 2014

This has been a challenging year for NZRA. We are still trying to find a structure which combines regions and local hot spots into an effective national body. There is increasing distinction of two 'levels' of rogaining and we need to think about how to support both, as well as flows between them. On one hand there are many rogaines being run by various groups and individuals in many regions, typically up to 6-hour duration. These rogaines attract strong participation across a wide range of people because of their variety, handy location, and manageable duration. On the other hand, we have the championship level 24 hour events that are important to keep Kiwis engaged and competitive in international competition. Organisationally, these events are much more demanding, requiring access to large tracts of land and demanding standards of course-setting, while participation is much lower. Many smaller, local events lack the formality and rigour which build the discipline for both organisers and participants to underpin championship-level rogaining. We need to find ways to improve the flows from the shorter to the longer events.

We were unable to run a national championship in 2013, due to a shortage of volunteers with enough time and suitable land access. Some people believe that we should change the format of the national championships from one full 24 hour event to a series of shorter, less formal events, some of which may perhaps involve other disciplines such as cycling or metrogaines. While these options may have more popular appeal, both with competitors and organisers, we also have to recognise that the 24 hour format is likely to continue to be the international standard.

The Australian Rogaining Championships, run annually by one of the State organisations in a rotation, are now the Australasian Championships – that is, they are combined with New Zealand. It is our turn to run the Australasian Championships in 2016. These championships must meet strict criteria of organisation, vetting, and quality, and we risk losing the ability to provide this if we do not continue to have our own national championships.

We need a better and easier way of combining information and resources than the existing Committee structure. Perhaps if we re-form into local groups, there may be a better communication within each group, which may encourage more participation by new, younger volunteers. Rogaining has been built on the volunteer system as an underlying principle, but to continue, we need more and younger volunteers.

We may also need to look at our membership model again. A Subscription-based membership would at least ensure that our list was up-to-date, but would impose an additional administrative burden. However it may allow people to feel that they "own" the club, and may encourage them to participate more in organisation and planning of events.

Best wishes for a full rogaining year.

P. L. Squires.

Peter Squires, President
19th February, 2014